

## **“Palestinian Resistance”: The Rebrand of Terrorism Into Acceptable Jihad**

“Palestinian resistance” is not a neutral phrase. In modern Western discourse, it functions as a political and social rebrand for terrorism. It is a way to transform jihadist violence, suicide bombings, stabbings, shootings, systemic sexual assaults, kidnappings, rocket attacks, hostage-taking, and civilian massacres into the language of liberation.

This framing did not originate from Western journalists, student activists, or academics. It originated from the terrorist organizations themselves. Hamas, Palestinian Islamic Jihad, the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine, the Popular Resistance Committees, the al-Aqsa Martyrs Brigades, Lions’ Den, the Abu Ali Mustafa Brigades, the Izz ad-Din al-Qassam Brigades, the al-Quds Brigades, and other Palestinian terror factions have long described their violence against Jews and Israelis as “resistance,” “jihad,” “martyrdom,” and “liberation.” [1][2]

The danger is that this language has now migrated into Western media, academia, activism, and even educational discourse, where it can soften the moral reality of terrorism and normalize the idea that violence against Jews and Israelis is politically justified.

### **A. The Terror Groups Themselves Use “Resistance” as Their Branding**

Hamas is designated by the United States as a Foreign Terrorist Organization. The U.S. National Counterterrorism Center describes Hamas having roots in the Palestinian branch of the Muslim Brotherhood. Hamas’s October 7, 2023 Jihadist attack slaughtered nearly 1,200 people. Hamas’s military wing, the Izz ad-Din al-Qassam Brigades, presents its violence as sacred struggle and national liberation. [1][2]

Palestinian Islamic Jihad is also designated as a terrorist organization. Its armed wing, the al-Quds Brigades, openly frames violence against Israel through jihadist language. Like all other Palestinian terrorist organizations, PIJ does not exist to negotiate coexistence. It exists to wage jihad against Israel. [1][3]

The Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine, despite its Marxist branding, is also a designated terrorist organization. Its armed wing, the Abu Ali Mustafa Brigades, has participated in attacks against Israelis and promotes violence as “resistance.” The PFLP demonstrates that the “resistance” brand is not limited to Islamist groups; it is a shared propaganda framework across Palestinian extremist factions. The PFLP was designated as a Foreign Terrorist Organization and a Specially Designated Global Terrorist by the U.S. Department of State in October 1997 and October 2001, respectively. [1][4]

The al-Aqsa Martyrs Brigades, associated with Fatah, were designated by the United States as a Foreign Terrorist Organization in 2002. They emerged during the Second Intifada and became

known for shootings and suicide bombings. Their existence destroys the myth that Palestinian terrorism is confined only to Hamas or Islamic Jihad. [1]

Lions' Den, a newer armed faction based primarily around Nablus, presents itself as a grassroots "resistance" movement, but its activities include armed attacks and clashes. Its rise shows how the same old terror logic is being repackaged for the social-media age: masked gunmen, martyr posters, Telegram channels, viral funeral imagery, and slogans of resistance. [5]

### B. "Resistance" Turns Civilian Massacres Into Political Messaging

The word "resistance" is powerful because it changes the emotional frame. A terrorist becomes a "fighter." A suicide bomber becomes a "martyr." A massacre becomes an "operation." A hostage becomes a "prisoner." A civilian target becomes a "settler," "Zionist," or "enemy." That is the entire propaganda strategy.

When Hamas murders civilians, it does not describe the act as terrorism. It calls it resistance. When PIJ fires rockets toward Israeli towns, it calls it resistance. When the PFLP celebrates armed violence, it calls it resistance. When al-Aqsa Martyrs Brigades glorify attackers, they call it resistance. When Lions' Den militants publish armed videos, they call it resistance. [2][3][4]

This is a deliberate moral laundering process.

The Palestinian Authority's "pay-for-slay" system further institutionalizes this logic by financially rewarding prisoners convicted of terror attacks and supporting families of so-called "martyrs." This system creates a financial and cultural incentive structure around terrorism: the more severe the attack, the greater the symbolic and sometimes material status of the attacker. [6] [7]

This matters because terrorism does not survive only through violence and weapons. It survives through narrative. It needs schools, media, clerics, charities, student groups, NGOs, online influencers, and political movements to repeat its moral vocabulary until violence against Jews and Israelis sounds like justice.

### C. Western Institutions Are Repeating the Terrorists' Vocabulary

The central danger is not only that Palestinian terror groups call themselves "resistance." The danger is that Western institutions increasingly repeat that framing.

On campuses, in activist circles, in media spaces, and in parts of public discourse, "Palestinian resistance" is often used as justification for terrorist violence. It is framed in a way that blurs the line between a human rights cause and violent Jihadist ideologies. This creates moral confusion.

It allows people to condemn “terrorism” in theory while defending the exact Jihadist organizations, slogans, symbols, and tactics associated with terrorism in practice.

George Washington University’s Program on Extremism has documented how Hamas-related networks in America historically engaged in fundraising, lobbying, education, and propaganda dissemination. That finding is critical because it shows that the battle is not only military. It is ideological and institutional. [8]

The same pattern appears in the broader normalization of phrases such as “globalize the intifada,” “by any means necessary,” and “resistance is justified.” These slogans do not emerge in a vacuum. They echo the vocabulary of terrorist factions that have spent decades presenting anti-Jewish and anti-Israeli violence as revolutionary virtue.

The result is a dangerous inversion: the victims of terrorism are portrayed as oppressors, while terrorist organizations are reframed as liberation movements.

#### D. From “Resistance” to Respectability: The Mainstreaming of Terrorist Icons

One of the most striking consequences of the “resistance” rebrand is the normalization of individuals and organizations historically associated with terrorism.

Leila Khaled, a member of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP), became internationally known for participating in airline hijackings in 1969 and 1970. The PFLP remains designated as a terrorist organization by the United States. Yet in recent years, Khaled has repeatedly been invited to participate in academic events, conferences, webinars, and university discussions where she is frequently presented not as a terrorist operative, but as a symbol of Palestinian “resistance.” [9][10]

In 2020, San Francisco State University became the center of controversy after faculty organized a virtual event featuring Khaled. Zoom, YouTube, and Facebook ultimately restricted or removed portions of the event, citing concerns related to U.S. anti-terrorism policies and Khaled’s affiliation with the PFLP. [9][11][12]

Critics argue that the controversy highlighted a larger trend: the transformation of individuals once universally recognized as terrorists into celebrated political figures, revolutionary icons, or resistance heroes within segments of academia and activism.

Various activist organizations, student groups, and social-media campaigns have displayed images of Khaled carrying a rifle, promoted her speeches, sold merchandise bearing her image, or described her as a symbol of liberation rather than a terrorist. [13]

The same pattern can be seen in the glorification of imprisoned terrorists and members of designated terrorist organizations. Posters, murals, social-media graphics, and campus demonstrations have at times featured figures associated with Hamas, the PFLP, Palestinian Islamic Jihad, the al-Aqsa Martyrs Brigades, and other terrorist factions as symbols of resistance and heroism. This transforms terrorism into a celebrated form of political activism. [13]

Some activist campaigns in the West have portrayed the individuals known as the “Holy Land Five” as persecuted political figures or humanitarian victims. The “Holy Land Five” refers to executives of the Holy Land Foundation who were convicted in federal court on charges related to providing material support to Hamas. Supporters portray the men as victims of political persecution, contributing to the broader normalization of networks found by U.S. courts to have supported a designated terrorist organization. [14][15]

The broader concern is not merely that controversial speakers are invited to campuses. The concern is that terrorism itself is increasingly reframed through the language of resistance, liberation, decolonization, and social justice. Once that reframing takes hold, figures associated with terrorist organizations can be transformed from perpetrators of atrocities into celebrated symbols of political virtue.

This represents the ultimate success of the resistance narrative: not merely defending terrorism, but rendering it culturally acceptable.

## Conclusion

“Palestinian resistance” has become one of the most successful propaganda rebrands of modern terrorism. It allows jihadist, nationalist, Islamist, and Marxist terror organizations to package violence as a moral struggle.

Hamas, Palestinian Islamic Jihad, the PFLP, the Popular Resistance Committees, al-Aqsa Martyrs Brigades, Lions’ Den, and related armed factions do not merely use violence. They use language to sanctify violence. They call terrorism resistance because the word helps launder murder into politics.

Western institutions must stop repeating the vocabulary of terrorist organizations as if it were neutral analysis. Rebranding terrorism as “resistance” is not human rights work. It is terrorist propaganda. And when that propaganda enters universities, media, classrooms, nonprofits, and political movements, it does what terrorism itself seeks to do: normalize Jihadist violence and desensitize the public to violence against civilians.

## Footnotes

[1] U.S. Department of State — Foreign Terrorist Organizations

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[2] U.S. National Counterterrorism Center (NCTC) — Hamas

<https://www.dni.gov/nctc/groups/hamas.html>

[3] U.S. National Counterterrorism Center (NCTC) — Palestinian Islamic Jihad

[https://www.dni.gov/nctc/terrorist\\_groups/pij.html](https://www.dni.gov/nctc/terrorist_groups/pij.html)

[4] U.S. Department of the Treasury — Treasury Disrupts Sham Overseas Charity Networks Funding Hamas and the PFLP

<https://home.treasury.gov/news/press-releases/sb0162>

[5] Reuters — Explainer on Lions' Den Armed Group

<https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/what-is-palestinian-militant-group-den-lions-2022-10-25/>

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[7] U.S. Taylor Force Act

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[8] George Washington University Program on Extremism — Hamas Networks in America

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[15] United States Court of Appeals, Holy Land Foundation Case.

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[20] National Counterterrorism Center (NCTC). Counterterrorism Guide and Foreign Terrorist Group Profiles.

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